long journey required a company of twelve men at least so that they could relieve each other. Each man cost four rupees a month. Of course, if one wanted to make a statement, one could hire twenty to thirty armed guards who came with muskets and bows. These cost as much as the palanquin-bearers but were higher in status. In addition, Tavernier says, the English and Dutch officials also insisted on a flag-bearer who walked in front of the party in honour of their respective companies. I suppose this is the origin of the little flags that modern-day ambassadors and dignitaries have fluttering in front of their luxury cars.

On 6 December 1665, Bernier and Tavernier met each other on the banks of the Ganga near Allahabad. They drank a toast of wine mixed with water on the banks of the river—but this seems to have upset Tavernier's stomach. A couple of days later they crossed the river at Allahabad but had to wait half the day for the governor to send them entry/exit permits. Revenue officials stood on both banks, checked papers and charged octroi. Wagons were charged four rupees each and carriages one rupee. The boatman had to be paid separately.

In addition to the Sadak-e-Azam highway through the Gangetic plains, there were many other internal trade routes that continued to thrive. As per a tradition that went back to ancient times, trees were planted all along the way to provide shade. This custom survived into the twentieth century but is unfortunately no longer adhered to. In the south, the road through the Palghat Gap continued to be used to connect the ports of the Kerala coast with the interior. However, the old Dakshina Path route appears to have gone into decline during this period. Instead, there were a number of important trade routes that linked the imperial capitals of Agra and Delhi with the ports of Gujarat. For instance, a route used by Peter Mundy of the English East India Company originated in Agra and made its way south-west through Fatehpur, Bayana, Ajmer, Jalore, Mehsana, Ahmedabad and finally to Surat. An alternative route was to head more directly south from Delhi–Agra to Dholpur, Gwalior, Narwar, Ujjain and finally to Mandu. From Mandu the route turned west to Surat. Bernier tells us that goods from Surat made it to Delhi in four–six days.